

WELCOME TO FATE'S EDGE

Fate's Edge is a narrative-first TTRPG where every action has a cost, the fiction leads the rules, and tension flows from *Position*, *Effect*, and *Story Beats (SB)*. This quickstart gives you the complete table loop.

Golden Rule

When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story. The dice help decide which path you take.

CORE RESOLUTION

The Art of Consequence

Every meaningful action follows three steps:

1. **Approach:** Player declares intent and method in the fiction.
2. **Execution:** Roll a pool = *Attribute + Skill* (d10s).
Each 6–10 = 1 success. Each die showing 1 = 1 *SB* to the GM.
3. **Outcome:** Compare successes to *DV* (Difficulty Value).
GM resolves using *Position & Effect* and spends SB for complications.

Attributes (1–5)

- **Body:** Strength, exertion, taking hits
- **Wits:** Perception, speed of thought, timing
- **Spirit:** Will, intuition, focus
- **Presence:** Poise, command, social force

Skills (0–5)

- **Melee, Ranged, Athletics**
- **Sway, Subterfuge, Insight**
- **Stealth, Survival, Command**
- **Arcana, Lore, Craft (Tinker)**

Subterfuge

Subterfuge = disguise, forgery, cons, planted evidence, social camouflage.

Stealth = not being seen or heard while moving or waiting.

Craft (Tinker) = devices, locks, traps, seals, wards, and tools.

Guidance: Paper and posture → **Subterfuge**. Avoiding notice → **Stealth**. Pins and gears → **Craft (Tinker)**.

Difficulty Values (DV)

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DV Situation	
2	Routine: clear intent, modest stakes
3	Pressured (default): time pressure or mild resistance
4	Hard: hostile conditions or active opposition
5+	Extreme: multiple constraints, high precision

Position & Effect

- **Position:** *Dominant* (safe), *Controlled* (default), *Desperate* (high stakes).
- **Effect:** *Limited* (small), *Standard* (expected), *Great* (big).

Shifting Position

- **Improve:** advantage, leverage, tools, solid prep, or spend a Boon (+1 step).
- **Worsen:** alarms, pressure, exposure, or GM SB spend (−1 step).

Evolving Position

Start: Dominant (quiet corridor).
Noisy pick (1 SB) → Controlled (patrol turns).
Reinforcements (2 SB) → Desperate (crossfire).

Outcome Matrix

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Result What Happens	
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB=0	Clean Success: intent achieved
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB $\geq$ 1	Success & Cost: intent + complications
0 < Successes < DV	Partial: progress with complication (gain 1 Boon)
Successes = 0	Miss: no progress (gain 2 Boons)

Story Beats (SB): Simple Spend Menu

- **1 SB** — Minor pressure: noise, trace, drop a tool, tick a 4/6 clock +1.
- **2 SB** — Moderate setback: lose Position, raise alarm, harsher terms.
- **3 SB** — Serious trouble: reinforcements, break an asset, split the party.
- **4+ SB** — Major turn: authority arrives, environment shifts, Patron interferes.

DESCRIPTION LADDER

How you describe your action adds optional re-rolls (all 1s still generate SB):

- **Basic:** roll as-is.
- **Detailed:** re-roll one die showing 1.

- **Intricate:** re-roll all 1s; add a flourish on success.

Flavor is Free

Add descriptive details, cultural elements, and atmospheric touches without spending resources. Describe the flourish, the scar, the whistle. Mechanics determine success or failure; flavor determines the story we tell about it.

BOONS: REWARD FOR RISK

- **On Miss (0 successes):** gain **2 Boons**.
- **On Partial:** gain **1 Boon**.

Spending Boons

- Re-roll one die in any pool
- Activate an on-screen Asset
- Improve Position by 1 step
- Convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (max 2 XP/session)

Limits

- Hold up to 5 Boons (trim to 2 at scene end)
- Max 2 Boons from failure per scene

ACTION ECONOMY

Each turn:

- **1 Action:** attack, cast, use a skill, or similar task.
- **1 Move:** shift one Range Band (Close↔Near or Near↔Far). *Dash* (spend the Action) = move two bands.

Talents may grant bonus actions or reactions. Fatigue or harm can restrict options.

COMBAT SYSTEM

Same core loop, now framed for danger.

Procedure

1. Declare action and approach
2. GM sets *Position* and *Effect*
3. Roll Attribute + Skill dice

4. Count successes vs DV (1s generate SB)
5. GM resolves and spends SB

Combat Position

Dominant: advantage, cover, tempo *Controlled:* default exchange *Desperate:* flanked, exposed, or collapsing ground

Turn Order

No fixed initiative. Spotlight follows fiction:

- Ambushers act first; targets respond after the opening beat.
- Players may propose acting when it makes sense.
- GM shifts spotlight to maintain tension and clarity.

Fatigue

Track: Fatigue = *Body*. Mark for exertion, strain, backlash.

Effect: Each Fatigue step worsens Position by one level (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate).

If already *Desperate*, take *−1 die* per additional Fatigue.

Overflow: When full, increase *Harm* by 1 step and clear all Fatigue.

Recovery: Short rest clears 1–2; full night clears all.

Harm

- **Level 1:** Minor (−1 die to related actions)
- **Level 2:** Serious (−1 die to most actions)
- **Level 3:** Critical (incapacitated/dying)

Tactical Clocks

- **Mob Overwhelm** [6]
- **Fatigue Spiral** [4]
- **Morale Collapse** [6]
- **Environmental Collapse** [8]

MAGIC SYSTEM

Three Paths

- **Caster (Freeform):** *Weave* elements + *Channel* power. (Requires *Spellcraft*.)
- **Runekeeper (Rites):** Patron-bound rites with *Obligation*. (Requires *Codex*; *Thaisos* shapes practice.)
- **Invoker (Symbols):** Patron *Seals* and rituals with time or risk.

TAGS System

TAGS are narrative shorthand for magical effects.

- **DV Calculation:** $DV = 1 + \text{number of TAGS (max 6)}$
- **Dangerous TAGS:** [TELEPORT], [TRANSFORM], [DOMINATE] add +2 DV instead of +1
- **Example:** “Burning • Area • Force” = DV 4

Casting At a Glance

- **Caster:** *Channel + Weave* = 2 actions (or *Push* to compress with cost).
- **Runekeeper:** 1 action to *Invoke*; may *Push* for +1 Obligation.
- **Invoker:** Rituals take turns; *Crack the Seal* for instant cast at *Desperate*.

Interrupt & Push

- **Interrupted:** If harmed/silenced before resolution, spell/rite fails.
- **Push:** Resolve now, mark +1 Fatigue or +1 Obligation/Corruption.
- **TAGS Backlash:** On mixed results, Backlash is colored by the TAGS used.

On-the-Fly Adjudication

Barrier for a hallway? [WARD] $\Rightarrow$ DV 2; scene-wide $\Rightarrow$ DV 3; sweeping area $\Rightarrow$ DV 4+. Casting under fire $\Rightarrow$ Controlled or Desperate.
Example: “I create a [WARD] [BARRIER] [FIRE] wall” = DV 4 (1+3)

CHARACTER CREATION

Starting Build

- **30 XP** to spend
- Attributes 1–3; Skills 0–2
- Bonds (+2 XP) and Complications (+4 XP) optional (max start 34 XP)

Key Talents

- **Spellcraft (6 XP)** [FIRE] [WATER]: access to freeform magic
- **Familiar (2 XP)** [SPIRIT] [BOND]: Patron features access
- **Codex (4 XP)** [FATE] [RITUAL]: Runekeeper rites & Obligation
- **Patron’s Symbol (4 XP)** [WARD] [SIGIL]: Invoker seals/rituals

RANGE BANDS & MOVEMENT

Range Bands

- **Close:** arm's reach
- **Near:** same room/space
- **Far:** line-of-sight distance
- **Absent:** off-screen (requires travel)

Movement

- 1 Move = shift one band (Close↔Near or Near↔Far)
- *Dash* (spend Action) = shift two bands
- Melee Flag: mark engaged foes in *Near* range

TRAVEL FRAMEWORK

Procedure

1. Break journey into legs with **Travel Clock** [4]
2. Assign roles: **Guide**, **Scout**, **Quartermaster**, **Watch**
3. Advance clock via actions/encounters
4. Resolve complications when the clock fills

Travel Roles

- **Guide:** on success, DV −1 for movement challenges
- **Scout:** on success, ignore the next 1 SB spend
- **Quartermaster:** on success, reduce Supplies Clock by 1
- **Watch:** on success, start next scene at *Dominant*

DECK OF CONSEQUENCES (OPTIONAL)

- **Hearts** — Social/emotional fallout
- **Spades** — Physical harm/danger
- **Clubs** — Resource/fatigue pressure
- **Diamonds** — Arcane/supernatural turns

Triggers (Draw 1; max 3/scene)

- A *Desperate* roll succeeds with cost
- GM spends 2+ SB at once
- A major clock fills (scene pivot)

ADVANCEMENT

XP Awards

- Standard: 6–10 XP / session
- Major objectives: +2–4 XP
- Discovery: +1–2 XP
- Hard choices: +1–2 XP
- Milestones: +8–12 XP / arc

Spending XP

- Attributes: new rating $\times$ 3 XP
- Skills: new level $\times$ 2 XP
- Talents: as listed (2–6+ XP)
- Followers: Cap² XP

GM QUICK REFERENCE

Adjudication Loop

1. Set Position and DV
2. Roll Attribute + Skill (6+ = success; 1 = SB)
3. Check Outcome Matrix
4. Spend SB to escalate
5. Advance clocks, move the fiction

No-Thinking SB Spend

- 1 SB:** minor pressure (*worsen Position* or tick 4/6 +1).
- 2 SB:** remove cover, split the party, tick environment +2.
- 3 SB:** reinforcements, break an asset, force a hard choice.
- 4+ SB:** scene transformation, authority arrival, collapse/eruption.

Five-Second Position & Effect

Ask two questions: *What is the risk?* (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate). *What is the impact?* (Limited/Standard/Great). Decide, roll.

Lazy DV Table

If in doubt: **DV = 3**. Raise/lower by 1 based on pressure or precision.

Clocks: The Three-Clock Rule

Keep at most three active:

- **Scene** (e.g., Guards Alerted [4])
- **Journey** (e.g., Mist Encroaches [6])
- **Campaign** (e.g., Baron's Suspicion [8])

WORKED EXAMPLES

Lockpick Under Pressure

Situation: Picking a warded lock while guards patrol nearby.

Roll: Wits 2 + Craft (Tinker) 2 = 4d10 → 8, 6, 3, 1.

Result: 2 successes (DV 2), 1 SB.

Outcome: Lock opens; GM spends 1 SB: the last pin clicks too loud—boots turn your way. Position worsens to *Controlled*.

False Orders

Situation: Planting forged orders to redirect a patrol.

Roll: Wits 3 + Subterfuge 2 = 5d10.

On Success: Patrol peels off; Effect improves if you also present matching seals (*Craft* assist).

On Partial: Rumor [2] starts against you; you gain 1 Boon.

On Miss: The captain cross-checks—GM spends SB to tighten security.

From Dominant to Desperate

Setup: Thane fires from cover (Dominant).

Roll: 6d10 → 10, 9, 7, 6, 3, 1 (SB=1). Clean hit (Great).

SB Spend: 1 SB—return fire chips the pillar, reducing cover. Next ally acts at *Controlled*. Two more SB later, a mob arrives; the scene slips to *Desperate*.

TAGS in Action

Situation: Wielder of the Fire and Water paths attempts to create a wall of flame.

Declaration: “I unleash [Burning] [Area] [Force] against the marauders.”

DV: 1 + 3 TAGS = 4

Roll: Arcana 3 + Lore 2 = 5d10 → 10, 8, 5, 4, 1

Result: 4 successes (DV 4), 1 SB (Clean Success)

Outcome: Wall of flame erupts; GM spends SB to have the fire spread to nearby tents.

STARTER SCENARIO: THE LANTERN AT DUSK

Premise

Escort a relic lantern across the haunted Duskway. When lit, forgotten souls stir. Patrons may contest the route.

Setup

- Party at **Tier I** (or use pregens).
- Relic Lantern: on loss, trigger Patron consequence.
- Prepare a **Travel Clock [4]** for the Duskway.

Encounter Seeds

1. **Shattered Bridge** DV 3 (Athletics/Survival/Craft). *SB*: falling stones, time pressure. On failure: clock +1.
2. **The Toll of Cinders** Parley (Presence+Sway) or trick (*Wits+Subterfuge*). *SB*: ambush, harsher terms.
3. **Lantern Awakens** When Travel Clock fills, ghostlight swells: *Restless Dead Mob [6]*. *SB*: lantern leaks; terrain turns treacherous.

Scene Clocks

- **Travel [4]** — legs of the road
- **Lantern Integrity [6]** — damage/corruption
- **Bandit Morale [4]** — collapses on fill

Outcomes

- **Success:** delivered; +6 XP, Patron favor, 1 contact
- **Mixed:** damaged; XP + ongoing Patron Obligation
- **Failure:** lost; +2 XP; introduce a Patron foe next session

SESSION ONE AGENDA (60/120 MINUTES)

1. Cold open: concrete stakes (5–10m).
2. Teach core loop with a short obstacle (10–15m).
3. Run one travel leg or social scene (15–25m).

4. Spotlight combat with clocks & SB (25–40m).
5. Debrief: XP, Boons, next hook (5–10m).

DESIGNERS NOTES

1. **Fail Forward:** failure is story fuel, not a stall.
2. **Fiction First:** description sets DV, Position, and Effect.
3. **SB Economy:** spend often; let tension breathe.
4. **Player Agency:** choices alter the map and the ledger.